



Let's Learn C

- By Aditya Varma

Preface

Welcome to Let's Learn C

This book is written to help you learn C as a skill, not as a subject.

C is a language that shows how programs really work. It does not hide details or make assumptions for you. Because of this, learning C builds a strong foundation that makes other languages easier to understand later.

The chapters in this book are arranged carefully. Each concept is introduced only when it is needed, and every idea is supported by simple programs that explain *why* something works, not just *how* to write it.

No prior programming knowledge is assumed. You are expected only to read, practice, and stay curious. This book is meant to be read slowly, like a guide. Type the programs. Modify them. Observe what changes.

Take your time. Ask questions. Make mistakes. That is how real understanding is built.

-Aditya Varma

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Icons and illustrations are inspired by open-source resources and custom designs created for this book.

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Getting Started with C

C Programming, created by Dennis Ritchie, C is a general-purpose, high-level programming language. It was created at Bell Labs in the early 1970s. One of the first operating systems to be written in C was UNIX. Even today's modern OSs have certain core parts written in C. These include Windows, Mac OS, and even Linux.

C is a perfect choice for learning to code if you are a beginner.

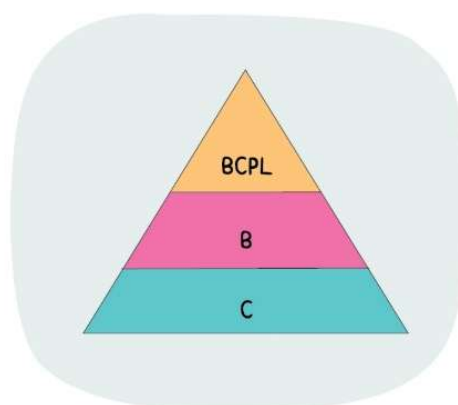
History Of C:

In the late 1960s, a high-level programming language called BCPL was created by Martin Richards, this language aimed to create a readable programming language that can be used to write Operating Systems (OS).

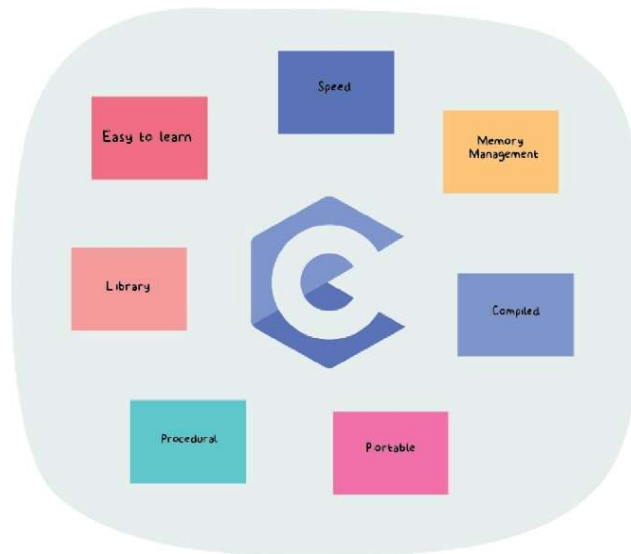
Back in those days, the programs for writing OS were not at all human-readable. This was limiting the adoption of computers for commercial purposes. And hence, this language was invented which was further improved by Ken Thompson and named "B". These languages did solve a lot of problems, but there was still an issue with memory management. Those were the old times and every byte of memory was important.

Dennis Ritchie saw this as a perfect opportunity to improve upon the B language. He tried to provide programmers with lots of memory optimization instructions along with inheriting a bulk of concepts from this existing language, B.

Since it was an improvement over the 'B' language, it was named as C Programming language. Quite convenient, eh?



Features of C:



Let's see a few reasons why you should choose C. Below are some of its amazing features.

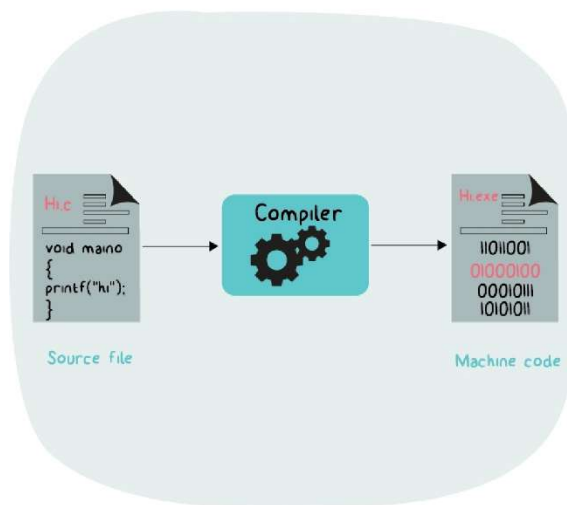
- **Easy-to-learn:** C has few keywords, a simple structure, and a clearly defined syntax. This makes it easy to catch for beginners
- **Speed:** The execution time for a C code is not the fastest among all programming languages. But its speed improves as the quantity of data to be processed increases astronomically
- **Memory Management:** C provides a variety of instructions to handle the memory allocation of its resources. If something can be achieved using lesser resources, C has the means to achieve that
- **Broad standard library:** C's bulk libraries are very portable and cross-platform compatible with UNIX, Windows, and Macintosh
- **Compiled Language:** Being a high-level language, its English-like instructions are converted into machine-level code using a software program called Compiler
- **Portable:** C can run on a wide variety of hardware platforms and has the same interface on all of those
- **Procedural Language:** Unlike an OOP language that is divided into objects and classes, C is divided into procedures or functions. This is like dividing your code into an exact set of steps to be performed.

How C Works?

C is a compiled language; it uses compiler to execute the program.

But what is a Compiler? It is a computer program that translates code written in one programming language into another language. What we as developers code is very English-based sentences. E.g. - `PRINT("SOMETHING");` This instruction needs to be converted into a machine-understandable code.

Also, a developer's code might be distributed in different files (imagine tens of documents). It is the job of the compiler to link all these files and create a final executable object that can run on the system.

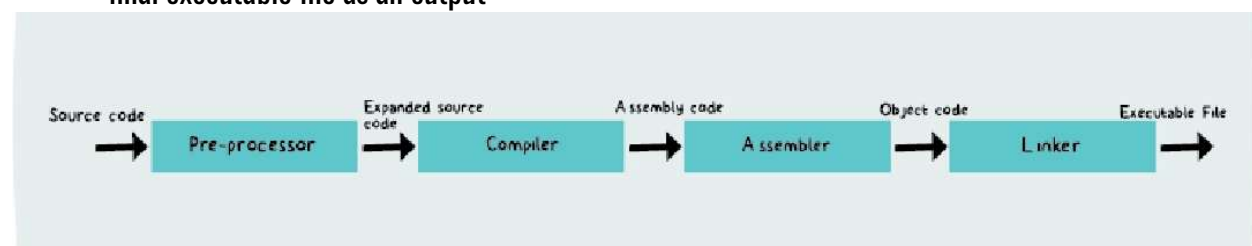


Compiled languages are converted directly into machine code that the processor can execute. As a result, they tend to be faster and more efficient to execute than interpreted languages.

Steps in Compilation:

It can be divided into 4 main tasks and they are performed in the following order,

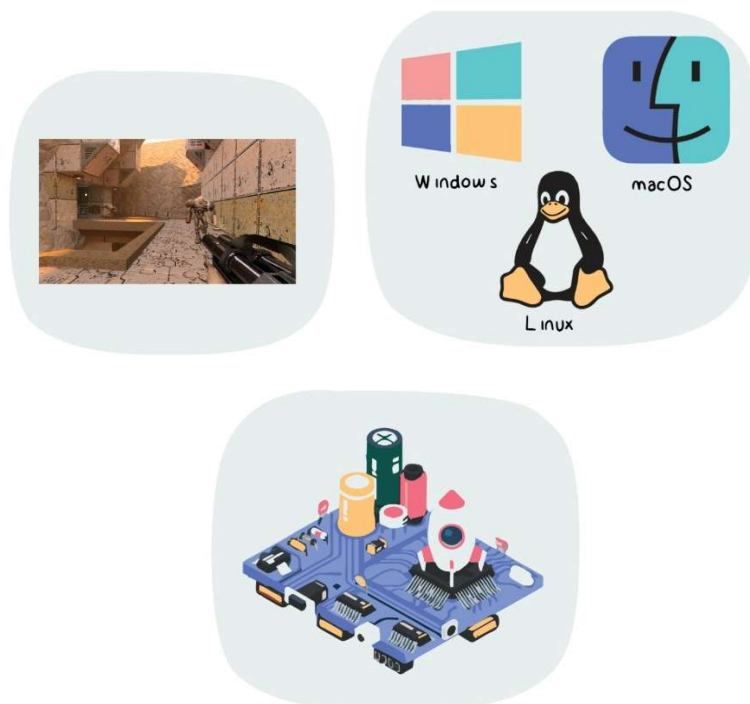
1. **Preprocessor:** This readies the code for execution by removing any comments, replacing procedure calls with actual code
2. **Compilation:** It converts pre-processed code into assembly (low-level) language
3. **Assembler:** This converts assembly language code into machine code, that is a string of 1's and 0's (binary code)
4. **Linker:** A project will have multiple files containing the source code. The linker will give one final executable file as an output



Where is C used?

Do you remember that we defined C as a general-purpose programming language? This means it is used in most places! And that's the reason why developers love C so much. C is used for,

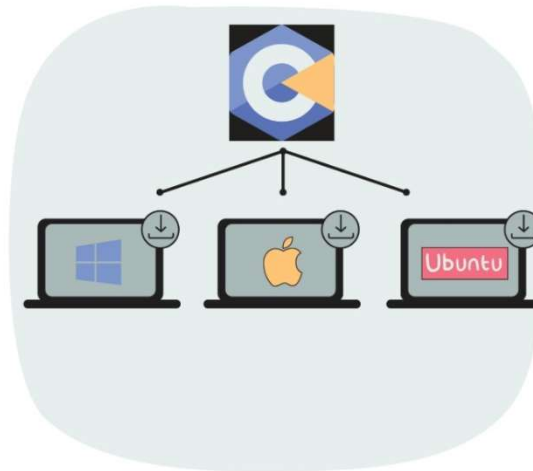
- **Desktop App Development:** C can be used to write any desktop application that you wish to develop. From a music player to photo-editing software, C has been already used. Certain parts of Mozilla Firefox Browser are written using C language.
- **Game Development:** C has a rich set of predefined graphics functions that aid in building video games. Till the early 2000s, C was heavily used for building games. The popular Unity game engine has several parts implemented using C.
- **Embedded Systems:** Due to its feature of memory management, C is the top choice for embedded systems development. It deals with microcontrollers or microprocessors, say, any machine that is controlled via inputs. C is used to create a logic that can control such devices. From rockets flying into space to a tiny smartwatch, C can handle them all!
- **Operating Systems:** We have already seen that C is used in the development of Operating Systems. In fact, it was created for this very purpose. Almost all major operating system's core kernel is written fully or partially using C. Not just operating systems, C is used to build compilers as well. That means new programming languages can also be made in C.



These are just a few of the applications noted here. C's prominent hold is on the embedded systems. That makes it a go-to language if you are thinking of a career in IoT. Of course, your options are not just limited to that. It's a 50 years old language but it surely has a future and rightly proves that - Old is Gold!

Installing C and its IDE:

To work with C on your machine, first, you will need to install the C Compiler in your system. It is unlikely that your system will be shipped with C Compiler.



Almost every C programmer uses the simplest way for getting this by using the GCC compiler. But first, would you like to know what GCC is? GCC stands for GNU Compiler Collection, it is an open-source compiler that supports the execution of multiple programming languages like C, C++, Fortran, Golang, and more.

GCC has been ported to multiple platforms and hence it helps in building C programs on a wide variety of systems. Currently, GCC's appropriate version for multiple platforms is available widely and for free.

But we are going to use something more efficient i.e., “Codeblocks”.

Installing Code::Blocks with MinGW:

Before we start writing C programs, we need a place to write and run them. For this, we will use Code::Blocks, which comes with a built-in C compiler called MinGW. Follow the steps carefully.

Step 1: Download Code::Blocks

- Open your browser
- Search for: Code::Blocks official website
- Open the website:
 - 👉 Code::Blocks
- Go to the Downloads section
- Click on “Download the binary release”

Step 2: Choose the Correct Version

You will see multiple options. Choose the one that includes MinGW.

- Look for a file named similar to:
codeblocks-20.03mingw-setup.exe

⚠ Important:

- Always choose the version with “mingw” in the name
- This version already contains the C compiler
- No need to install anything separately

Step 3: Install Code::Blocks

- Double-click the downloaded .exe file
- Click Next → I Agree → Next
- Keep default settings
- Click Install

Once installation completes:

- Click Finish

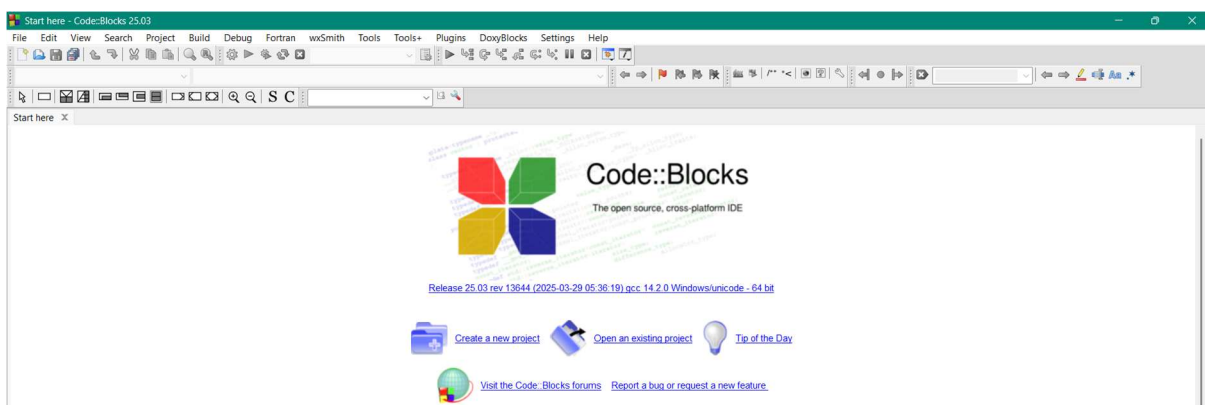
Step 4: First Launch Setup

- Open Code::Blocks
- It may ask to select a compiler

If prompted:

- Choose: GNU GCC Compiler
- Click Set as default
- Click OK

The setup is done and screen will look like this:



Creating files in Code::Blocks:

Step 1: Create Your First Project

- Click on Create a new project
- Select Console Application
- Click Go → Next
- Choose language: C
- Click Next

Step 2: Set Project Details

- Enter a Project Title (e.g., MyFirstProgram)
- Choose a folder location
- Click Next → Finish

Step 3: Write Your First Program

You will see a default file (main.c).

- Inside it, you can write your first program
- Or modify the existing code

Step 4: Build and Run the Program

- Click on Build and Run (green play button)
OR press F9
- Output will appear in a console window

At this stage, do not worry about:

- How the compiler works internally
- Complex settings
- Advanced configurations

Right now, your goal is simple:

Write → Run → Observe

First C Program & Boilerplate

After setting up the environment, the next step is simple: write something and see it work. Your first program is not about complexity. It is about starting a conversation with the computer.

Let us begin with a small program:

A screenshot of a code editor window titled "First.c". The code is written in C and consists of six lines. Line 1: `#include <stdio.h>`. Line 2: (empty). Line 3: `int main() {`. Line 4: `printf("Hello, World!");`. Line 5: `return 0;`. Line 6: `}`. The code is color-coded: `#include` is green, `<stdio.h>` is green, `int` is blue, `main()` is blue, `{` is blue, `printf` is blue, `"Hello, World!"` is in quotes, `return` is blue, `0` is blue, and `}` is blue.

When you run this program, the output will be:

A screenshot of a terminal window. The output of the program is displayed in white text on a black background. The first line is "Hello, World!". The second line is "Process returned 0 (0x0) execution time : 0.163 s". The third line is "Press any key to continue."

This is your program speaking back to you.

Understanding the Program

Let us read the program like we read a sentence.

The line `#include <stdio.h>` is written at the top. This line tells the program to bring in a set of tools before starting. These tools help in performing input and output operations. Since we are using `printf()` to display something on the screen, this line becomes necessary.

The next line, `int main()`, is where execution begins. Every C program starts from `main()`. When the program runs, the computer looks for this function and starts executing from here.

The curly braces `{ }` define a block. Everything written inside these braces belongs to the `main()` function. It is simply a way of grouping instructions together.

Inside this block, we have the line:

`printf("Hello, World!");`

This is the instruction that produces output. `printf()` is used to display text on the screen, and whatever is written inside the quotes gets printed.

Finally, we see:

```
return 0;
```

This marks the end of the program. It tells the system that the program has finished executing successfully.

Trying It Yourself:

Once you run the program, try changing the message:

```
printf("I am learning C.");
```

Or:

```
printf("This is my first program.");
```

Run it again and observe the output.

This simple action changing something and observing the result is where real learning begins.

Boilerplate Code

If you look at the program again, you will notice something interesting. Some parts of the program are not changing. No matter what you print, certain lines remain the same.

This repeated structure is called **boilerplate code**.

Boilerplate code is the basic structure required for a C program to run. It is not specific to one program. Instead, it acts as a standard starting point.

A simple version of boilerplate looks like this:

```
1  #include <stdio.h>
2
3  int main() {
4      // your code will go here
5      return 0;
6  }
```

This structure will appear in almost every C program you write.

Understanding Boilerplate Naturally

Instead of memorizing it, try to understand its role.

- The `#include` line brings in required tools.
- The `main()` function defines where execution starts.
- The curly braces hold the instructions.
- The `return 0` ends the program properly.

Everything you write will go inside this structure.

